

Bacterial and parasitic STDs

If someone has a sexually transmitted disease (STD), also known as a sexually transmitted infection (STI), it can be spread by vaginal, oral, or anal sex. STDs can have a variety of causes, among them bacterial and parasitic infections.

STD testing

Not all STDs cause symptoms, and it's possible to have one without knowing it. If a teen has had unprotected sex or is concerned they may have an STD, they should visit a doctor or sexual health clinic to be tested. This is sometimes called "getting screened." Clinics are confidential and available to everyone of all genders or ages.

For some tests, the results are instantaneous; others might take a few weeks to come through. If a teen tests positive for an STD, they will be given treatment, and should tell their partner and any previous partners.

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GOOD TO KNOW

What to expect

An STD screening might involve a blood or urine test, a sample from the urethra or the vagina, or a genital examination. You'll also be asked some questions:

- Why do you think you might have an STD?
- When did you last have sex, and have you ever had unprotected sex?
- What symptoms do you have, if any?

Bacterial STDs

Bacteria are microscopic, single-celled organisms that exist in air and water, on objects, and in the body. Bacteria can benefit the human body—for example, by aiding digestion—but some types can cause harm.

	Causes	Symptoms	Diagnosis	Treatment
Chlamydia	Chlamydia can be caused by unprotected vaginal, anal, or oral sex, or sexual contact, including sharing sex toys.	Mostly there are no symptoms, but there could be pain when urinating; discharge from the vagina, penis, or rectum; pain in the abdomen; bleeding during or after sex; bleeding between periods; or pain and swelling in the testicles. If left untreated, chlamydia can cause potentially serious problems, including infertility.	Diagnosis is made by a urine test or by taking a swab from the affected area.	A course of antibiotics is the usual treatment.
Gonorrhea	Gonorrhea can be spread by unprotected vaginal, anal, or oral sex, or sharing sex toys.	Symptoms include pain or a burning sensation when urinating; discharge from the vagina or penis; pain or tenderness in the lower abdomen or testicles; pain during or after sex, and bleeding during or after sex or between periods; or heavy periods. Some people have no symptoms, however. It can cause serious long-term health problems if left untreated, including infertility.	A urine test or swab from the affected area can indicate gonorrhea.	Gonorrhea is usually treated with antibiotics.
Syphilis	It can be spread through unprotected vaginal, anal, or oral sex; sexual contact, including sharing sex toys, or skin-to-skin contact with syphilitic sore or rash.	Some people have no symptoms, but others may experience small painless sores or ulcers on the vagina, penis, around the anus, or in the mouth; blotchy red rash on the palms of the hands or soles of the feet; small skin growths; white patches in the mouth; tiredness; headaches; joint pains; a high temperature; and swollen glands in neck, groin, or armpits. Syphilis can spread to the brain or other parts of the body if it's not treated, causing serious, long-term problems.	A blood test is conducted.	Antibiotic injections are given to treat syphilis.